HUNGER PANGS

FOOD MOVEMENT, 1959

West Bengal



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It began as a protest against the B.C. Roy-led Congress government's indifference to the food crisis in Bengal, when rice began selling for Rs 28-30 per maund, and the subsequent hoarding and black marketing triggered a near-famine in the countryside. In no time, however, the movement, which began under the aegis of the CPI or Communist Party of India's Price Increase and Famine Resistance Committee (PIFRC), escalated into a mass uprising. Students from city schools and colleges flocked to the cause, as did peasants and the working class, braving batons and bullets. Descending soon into a vicious spiral of violence and counter-violence, a four-day bloody carnival (August 31-September 4, 1959) of arson and anarchy by protesters was met with the most brutal state repression. Kolkata witnessed reckless firing and lathi-charges, with official figures claiming 80 deaths and 3,000 injured. Hundreds went missing. Police would cordon off areas of retreat, turn off the street lights and beat up the protesters. The anarchist role of the leftist young brigade also came in for criticism. With things spinning out of control, the CPI called off the protest on September 26. The Opposition moved a no-confidence motion against the government, but it was defeated due to lack of numbers. The movement subsided but did not die, rearing its head again in 1966. ■ –Romita Datta

IN REMEMBRANCE August 31 is now Martyrs' Day; a plaque has been set up in their memory at the Subodh Mullick Square in Kolkata